



◀ FORTS OF ENSLAVEMENT

Enslaved Africans were brought to the coast of West Africa. Here, they were held in captivity in forts or castles, such as the Cape Coast Castle in Ghana (left). For most of them, these buildings were their last memories of Africa before being shipped off to the colonies.

The transatlantic slave trade

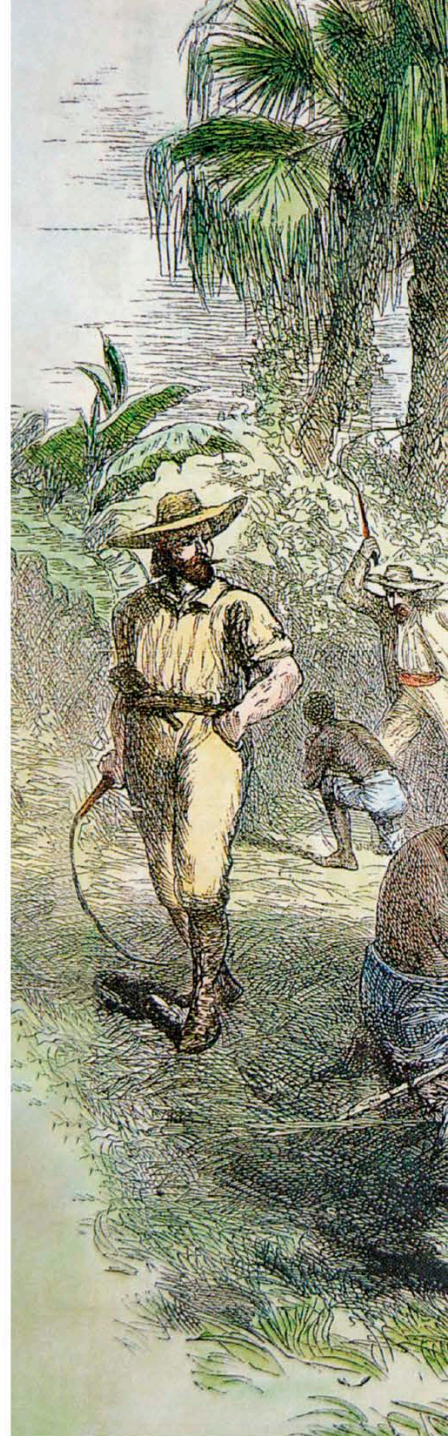
The settlement of new European colonies in the Americas led to the horrific enslavement of Africans. From the 16th to the mid-19th century, more than 12 million Africans were bought or kidnapped from their homes to be sold into a lifetime of hard labor. This has become known as the Ma'afa, a Kiswahili term meaning “great tragedy.”

Ravaged by war, plague, and famine in the 15th century, Europe needed fresh resources and found them in their newly established colonies in the Americas. But to gather these resources, labor was needed that could work the fields and mines.

Traders from Portugal, soon followed by other European countries, found a grim solution to this problem in Africa, and began buying human beings from Africa's western coast.

People were enslaved and shipped off to the colonies, and those who survived the journey were sold at auctions into a life of misery.

The riches extracted from the colonies made the West incredibly wealthy. Meanwhile, generations of enslaved Africans—and their descendants—struggled to fight for their rightful place in society as human beings worthy of dignity.



Up to 600 enslaved people had to lie on their backs to fit into the cramped space.

THE MIDDLE PASSAGE ▶

Once bought, captured Africans were chained in the lower deck of a ship for transport to the Americas. Called the “middle passage,” this journey could take up to 11 weeks and there was limited food, water, and sanitation available. Many did not survive the harsh journey.

